President Metsola's remarks at the European Council
18th December 2025, Brussels

Thank you, António.

The European Union is, by its very nature, a project for peace, and every genuine effort to spread peace should always - always - be welcomed. We've made real progress over the past weeks to end the war in Ukraine. This is the closest we've been to securing a peace deal, and we need to maintain the momentum.

At this critical moment, it remains strategically important that we keep placing our full weight behind Ukraine. We know, from experience, that for peace to be real and lasting, it must come with dignity, justice and freedom. That means strong security guarantees and respect for the principle of 'Nothing about Ukraine without Ukraine'. Those are the premise of any credible deal.

We cannot afford to show any signs of fragility or division. Russia needs to feel the pressure to come to the negotiating table - and it needs to see that it is impossible to drive a wedge between Europe, Ukraine and the United States.

For all our complications, majorities in the European Parliament on Ukraine remain strong. Since we last met, members adopted EDIP - the European Defence Industry Programme. We've reached an agreement with Council to bring an end to Russian gas imports - something the European Parliament long pushed for.

The most decisive factor right now is financing. Ukraine is running out of money. That is why we need to urgently find ways to raise the cost of Russia's war by doubling down on 'peace through strength.' The moment has come to move forward and present a strong front. When we say that Europe must take responsibility for its own security - this is what it takes.

You can count on the European Parliament to play its part. On the reparations loan, if there is a decision taken on this here, we will use our urgent procedure. We can then vote on it already in January and work quickly with Council to adopt it. We fully understand not just the importance of this step but the urgency of the moment.

On the topic of financing - negotiations on the Multiannual Financial Framework offer a unique opportunity to deliver a long-term budget that backs our priorities and is truly fit for purpose. Parliament's initial discussions have raised some concerns - on regions, on the Common Agricultural Policy and on governance. In this context, the Danish Prime Minister, the President of the European Commission and I had some really constructive discussions in our Article 324 meeting. We found compromises that brought us not just one, but two steps forward. And I think that says a lot about what we can achieve - and how quickly we can achieve it - when our institutions work together.

This leads me to our broader legislative work. The European Parliament is delivering. The procedural reforms we made last year have allowed us to work swiftly and effectively. In the last weeks alone, Parliament and Council have finalised work on the review of the Safe Third Country Concept, the agriculture omnibus, EDIP - the European Defence Industry Programme that I mentioned earlier, defence readiness, the 2040 target, deforestation, agricultural safeguards in the Mercosur trade agreement, the pharmaceutical package.

Many of them were identified as priorities in this year's Council Conclusions. We said we would get them done, and we have. On some files, it was Parliament that actually drove more ambitious outcomes.

The pace of our work will carry into the new year. I want to refer to two areas, in particular. Transatlantic trade remains critical, and when it comes to the implementation of the EU-US Framework Agreement, Parliament will adopt its position in January. I also want to outline Parliament's timeline on the Return Regulation.

The EU Pact on Migration and Asylum will be fully applicable mid-next year. Some elements are already in motion - I take this opportunity to welcome the recent agreement on the solidarity pool. As we speak, a trilogue is taking place on the EU list of Safe Countries of Origin and I am very optimistic it will be the last one. On the Return Regulation, our aim is to conclude it quickly, efficiently, with our sights set on starting negotiations with Council at the start of the year. As with the other files we have delivered this year, we will move efficiently - and we will deliver on this one as well.

Today, the European Parliament, Commission and Council will have signed a Joint Declaration which sets out our legislative priorities and that includes a list of ten files to guide our work over the next year. This is the first time in years that our three institutions have been able to agree on a common, focused set of priorities. This is a sign of unity we do not emphasise - or leverage - enough.

On the substance of the Joint Declaration, I want to make two comments. First, it is good to see the inclusion of the Automotive Package - something the European Parliament has eagerly awaited and will work on intensively. More generally on our work to make Europe more competitive, yes - simplifying rules for businesses matters. Latest projections point to a 1.4% GDP growth in the EU. Inflation has eased to 2%, while wages, on average, are rising faster. Our tech sector is once again driving employment, adding 1.6 million jobs this year. EU exports have largely rebounded, and industry is beginning to show signs of confidence - largely thanks to our work in giving businesses a breather.

But simplification is only one side of the coin. We also need to do more - much more to incentivise investment and complete the Single Market. These are the other parts of the Draghi Report we perhaps don't emphasise enough. Because ultimately, if we want to keep living like we do, we need to give our businesses the room to grow.

I want to conclude with a reminder on the targeted amendment to the EU Electoral Act to give female Members of European Parliament who are pregnant or who have just given birth the option to delegate their vote. I know many of you expressed your support - but we need to see this through. This means a lot to the European Parliament and its members. And it will send a strong message that when we say we stand by woman we don't just mean it with words, but more importantly, with action.

Thank you.